

Why Waiting is Worth It
A GRAMMAR OF AGENCY
Moral Action in an Age of Artificial Intelligence

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Preface

In *Magnifica Humanitas*, Pope Leo XIV contrasts the exploitative and extractive construction of the Tower of Babel (Gen. 11) with Nehemiah's communal, restorative rebuilding of the walls of Jerusalem (Neh. 4). I'd like to add to the image of Nehemiah gathering the group and assigning portions for each person to help protect and rebuild Jerusalem's wall, the image of the anchoress Julian of Norwich in her cell attached to the church beside the walls, with a window looking in to the altar and the other looking out for bread and counsel, as the keeper of the stories that sustain the current and seed the future generations. In that image, Nehemiah and Julian work together — he on the walls, protecting; she enclosed in her cell, with her cats, contemplating.

This capstone concludes three years of formation with the Lay Mission Institute and a small circle cohort in Danville, California and takes its name in deliberate dialogue with St. John Henry Cardinal Newman's *Grammar of Assent*. Newman argued that real certitude arises not from mechanical inference but from the convergence of interior faculties — a unity of mind, will, and perception. The *Grammar of Agency* stands on the same ground: that moral action, like assent, is not a mechanical output but a disciplined interior event. Where Newman traced the epistemic movement toward truth, this work traces the moral movement toward the good.

This latest iteration of the Grammar enters explicit communion with *Magnifica Humanitas*, the encyclical letter of Pope Leo XIV signed on 15 May 2026, the 135th anniversary of Leo XIII's *Rerum Novarum* and promulgated in a public forum at the Vatican on 25 May 2026. The convergence is not coincidental; it is the sign of a tradition that thinks together across time. Where the encyclical addresses the civilization, the Grammar addresses the person inside it. They share the same diagnosis: that the primary danger of artificial intelligence is not that machines become moral agents, but that human beings forget how to be. This version integrates the encyclical's social doctrine by restoring the universal destination of goods as the initial altitude instrument — the agent's first stance before God's gift — and situates the CST Fourfold Test as the primary operational reading of the moral field.

Without the Lay Mission disciple group at St. Isidore's in Danville and the brothers and sisters of St. Albert the Great's Lay Dominican Fraternity in Oakland, this would not have been possible. This is offered as seed to be spread.

Introduction

We live in a socially mediated, post-modern world increasingly saturated by generative artificial intelligence. More and more of our decisions — our opportunities to exercise judgment and our freedom for excellence — are quietly outsourced to the machine. The danger is not that the machine becomes a ghost in a shell; it is that the human becomes a hollow shell, having surrendered the work of her own soul. *Magnifica Humanitas* names this precisely: the risk is not that AI surpasses human intelligence, but that

human beings, habituated to outsourcing discernment, will cease to exercise the faculties that constitute genuine moral agency.^[2]

A recent California Court of Appeal episode illustrates the danger. In *Torres*,^[3] a client saw a case mentioned on Reddit and relayed it to her attorney. He cited it in a pleading. The court accepted the argument, directed opposing counsel to draft an order, and entered it. Not one person in that chain verified the citation. The case did not exist. The fundamental roles of Agent and Witness were abandoned in favor of a GenAI-mediated rumor.

The Grammar of Agency begins where Catholic Social Teaching begins: with God's gift. Before any act is evaluated, before any judgment is formed, the agent stands within the Creator's original intention — the universal destination of goods (UDG). *Magnifica Humanitas* extends this principle into the digital age: algorithms, data, platforms, and technological infrastructures are part of the common patrimony of the human family. When these goods are enclosed, concentrated, or used to displace human judgment, the agent's relationship to God's gift is distorted. Only on this foundation — God's gift, universally intended — can the Fourfold Test and the interior kata of judgment-premised processing operate at all.

Once anchored in the keel of UDG, the Grammar proceeds through a four-step kata with a necessary pause between the third and fourth steps: **Frame — Receive and Sense — Orient and Align** — [*Wu Wei* / Timing Belt] — **Act and Integrate**. We call this kata JPP: Judgment-Premised Processing. This grammar stands within a long lineage — from Aristotle to Aquinas, to Catherine of Siena, to Pinckaers, to John Paul II, to Leo XIV's social doctrine — because agency presents as virtue in motion.

The Thesis: Waiting is Worth It

The time taken allows reason — our shared participation in the mind of the Creator — to have its rightful place in the process, rather than being outsourced to something not made in the image of God.

Section I: The Mechanism of Displacement

The problem of agency in an AI age is not simply that machines now do things humans once did. It is that the outsourcing of cognitive and moral tasks reshapes the agent. *Magnifica Humanitas* names this the “technocratic paradigm”: the tendency to let the logic of efficiency, control, and profit alone shape personal, social, and economic decisions.^[4] When navigation is permanently delegated to GPS, spatial reasoning atrophies. When a recommendation engine curates every cultural encounter, the capacity for self-directed attention contracts. The loss is not the skill itself but the interior architecture that the skill required and sustained: the habit of judgment, the tolerance for ambiguity, the willingness to be wrong and correct course.

The structural architecture that the *Grammar of Agency* proposes in response is a metaphor representing a process: a ship of state in which the moral agent is the operator — steering stable in a chaotic world through the fusion of judgment and making (*Con+Facere*), held on course by the keel of revelation, tradition and practice, stabilized by the cardinal and transcendent virtues, and timed by *wu wei*. The problem of agency is the problem of maintaining all of these simultaneously, under load, in a world designed to make each one feel optional.

Section II: The Thomistic Foundation

Conscience as Act, Not Power

Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 79, A. 13), asks whether conscience is a power of the soul. His answer: conscience is not a power but an act — the act of applying knowledge to an individual case. *Conscientia*: knowledge held together with, knowledge applied in the moment of encounter. Conscience is an act, not a disposition.

This matters enormously for how we understand moral errors. If conscience were a power, moral failure would be a malfunction. But Aquinas tells us conscience is an act, which means moral failure is a failure of performance. And performance can be disciplined, trained, habituated. This is the opening through which formation enters. The *Catechism* (§37) reinforces this: error is rarely about lack of intelligence. It is almost always about disordered will.

The Two-Axis Model: What AI Can and Cannot Do

Magnifica Humanitas confirms the two-axis distinction from the doctrinal level: AI systems “merely imitat[e] certain functions of human intelligence” and “do not possess a moral conscience, since they do not judge good and evil, grasp the ultimate meaning of situations, or bear responsibility for consequences.”^[5]

Horizontal Axis <i>Cardinal Virtues</i>	Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, Temperance. Definable criteria, measurable distortions. A large language model can reason about justice with fluency, describe prudent action with precision. The horizontal plane is LLM-legible. AI lives here naturally and can provide genuine assistance to a human agent navigating this plane.
Vertical Axis <i>Transcendent Spine</i>	Faith, Hope, Love — the human-only virtues. These exceed calculation, cannot be automated, and belong uniquely to the human soul in its capacity for self-transcendence. AI can describe what a just act looks like. It cannot perform one. Without the vertical stabilizer, the

horizontal plane is merely optimization: fast, fluent, and flat.

Truth as the Epistemological Ground

Aquinas argues (*Summa Theologiae*, I, Q. 16, A. 6) that truth is one in its ground and many in its reception. Truth is not produced by the human mind; it is received. Conscience is not an authority that invents truth but a faculty that receives, recognizes, and applies it. This establishes the epistemological posture the Grammar requires: humility. *Magnifica Humanitas* returns to this directly: “the search for truth is an essential element of democracy,” and when pragmatism replaces it, “democratic life is weakened.”^[6]

Section III: The Grammar in Motion — CST-JPP

The Keel: Revelation, Tradition, and Practice

Catholic Social Teaching is the keel of this vessel. The keel is in explicit dialogue with *Magnifica Humanitas*, which stands as the most recent and most directly relevant development of that tradition. The encyclical does not replace earlier Social Doctrine; it deepens and applies it — continuing the line from Leo XIII’s *Rerum Novarum*, through John Paul II’s *Centesimus Annus*, Benedict XVI’s *Caritas in Veritate*, and Francis’ *Laudato Si’* and *Fratelli Tutti*. The Grammar inherits this whole lineage.

The Universal Destination of Goods: The Initial Altitude Instrument

Magnifica Humanitas extends the principle of universal destination of goods explicitly into the digital age: “today, among the goods that are universally intended for everyone, we must also include new forms of property, such as patents, algorithms, digital platforms, technological infrastructure and data.”^[7] When these goods remain concentrated in the hands of a few, “a new imbalance is created that contradicts the universal destination of goods.” This is not a new principle — it roots in John Paul II’s teaching that God gave the earth to the whole human race without excluding or favoring anyone^[8] — but its digital application is new, and the Grammar adds it as the initial altitude instrument.

Applying the Initial Altitude Instrument

Ask, before framing any specific act involving goods, knowledge, data, or access:

- Are the goods at stake — material, digital, or epistemic — being treated as common patrimony or as private enclosures?
- Does this action expand or restrict access for those without power or connection?

- Do the platforms, algorithms, or data systems involved serve the many or concentrate benefit for the few?
- Is the formation being offered here — including this Grammar itself — being held as seed to be spread, or as property to be controlled?

This instrument does not replace the Fourfold Test. It precedes it — setting the structural conditions under which just acts are possible at all.

The principle operates at the level of disposition, not just specific decisions. An agent formed in this principle does not ask “what must I share?” only when legally required. She asks, as a prior orientation of the will, what belongs to the commons by right of human solidarity — and resists the quiet normalization of enclosure that the digital economy rewards. This is, in *Magnifica Humanitas*’ terms, solidarity as “a way of making history” rather than an occasional corrective.^[9]

The Needs of the Soul: Rowlands, Weil, and the Roots of Agency

Anna Rowlands reads our moment, after Arendt, as a season of *dark times* — and retrieves Simone Weil to name what such times do to persons.^[20] Weil’s diagnosis was *uprootedness*: a civilization can sever people from the sources that nourish judgment, memory, and belonging.^[21] The Grammar’s mechanism of displacement is uprootedness in the digital key — the agent severed not from soil but from the interior faculties that the outsourced task once required. Weil also gives the Grammar the interior name for its central discipline: *attention* — the patient, self-emptying readiness to receive what is actually there before grasping at it. This is precisely the work of *Receive and Sense* and of the timing belt; the Witness Moment is an act of attention before it is anything else. Finally, Weil orders the social world by *obligation* before *right*: what is owed to every human person as a sacred reality precedes any claim. This is the floor beneath the universal destination of goods — the reason the gift belongs to the commons by right of solidarity, not by permission. Rowlands gathers these into a *politics of communion*: the person, like the Church, exists not for herself but for others. That is the social end toward which Con+Facere and the civilization of love are already ordered. The Fourfold Test that follows is the operational form of this communion: the four questions by which the agent reads, in any given moment, whether the gift is being kept in common.

The CST Fourfold Test: Primary Altitude Instrument

Catholic Social Teaching, in the Grammar of Agency, is not a library of principles to be consulted after the fact. It is an operator’s manual for moments — a way of reading the field that gives the agent moral altitude. The tradition is rendered as four questions, asked before action:

The Fourfold Test (Primary Kata Prompt)

- Does this action restore human dignity?
- Does it seed the garden of the common good?

- Is it sisterly and brotherly — does it strengthen solidarity?
- Does it uplift the little ones?

If the answer is not yes to all four, the action is not yet just. These are an altitude instrument — a continuous reading of the moral field, mapping onto CST's four pillars: human dignity, common good, solidarity, and the preferential option for the poor.

JPP: The Four Moves as Kata

Frame	Take in the moment. Achieve self-awareness and field awareness simultaneously. Snap in — be fully present to what is actually happening, not what you anticipated or feared.
Receive and Sense	Be actively passive. Open to what the moment is delivering before moving to interpret it. The senses gather; the intellect has not yet formed its judgment. This move requires stillness.
Orient and Align	Frame with purpose and direction. Turn toward the good. Ask: what is the right act here, for this person, in this moment, given what is at stake?
► The Space Between: Wu Wei — The Timing Belt <i>Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.</i>	
Act and Integrate	Now, in this moment, act. Assess and iterate. The act is complete when the field has been met and the agent has returned to readiness.

Wu Wei: The Timing Belt

Between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate there is a threshold. Its deepest philosophical roots form in classical Taoism: Lao Tzu composed the *Tao Te Ching* (道德經) in the 6th century BC. Its central practical teaching is *wu wei* — 無為 — the

discipline of action that does not force. Thomas Aquinas arrives at a formulation that resonates powerfully across the nineteen-century gap: prudence as *recta ratio agibilium* — right reason applied to action. Aquinas gives us the *what* and *why* of right judgment. The Tao gives us the *when* and *how not just yet*. Together, they constitute a complete account of moral action that neither tradition achieves alone.

Magnifica Humanitas names the same dynamic at the civilizational level: it warns against a culture that eliminates “the threshold between discernment and action” and calls for political capacity “to slow things down when everything is accelerating.”^[10] The Grammar names the interior equivalent: the recovery of *wu wei* is the only path back to agency, autonomy, and authentic human moral action.

Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

Mary & Julian: The Timing Belt in Two Keys

Mary's Fiat: Prudence in Docile Acceptance

The perfected integration of *wu wei* and *recta ratio agibilium*. Across the Annunciation, Cana, and Calvary, she reveals a single interior stance: not passivity, but formed readiness — prudence perfected in timing. At the Annunciation she receives, inquires proportionately, holds the moment open, and consents only when discernment has completed its interior work. At Cana she names the need and steps back: “Do whatever he tells you.” At Calvary she stands, grounded in faith and hope wrapped in love, neither collapsing nor seizing control. In each mystery, Mary embodies the union of temporal *wu wei* and Thomistic right action — the timing belt held open across decades, carried through the world, threaded through other people's crises and her own.

Julian at the Window: The Enclosed Threshold

Where Mary moves, Julian stays. The anchoress of Norwich holds the threshold open not by traveling through the world but by becoming a fixed point through which the world passes. Her cell is attached to the church — one window looking inward to the altar, one looking outward to the common ground. Through the outer window the people gather to share: gossip, bread, trouble, a cat, counsel. Julian receives it all. She is not withdrawn from the world; she is strategically available to those gathered, offering back the fruits of her contemplation. Her enclosure is not absence but concentrated presence. She is the timing belt as place rather than as motion — stillness that enables others to find the threshold they could not locate on their own. And from her stillness Julian reflects back to those gathered at her window, freely given.

Together, Mary and Julian answer the objection that *wu wei* is passivity or withdrawal. One is threading through Calvary; the other is holding the spiritual center of a city during plague. Neither collapses. Neither seizes. Both hold — and in holding, act.

The Lock: Judgment Applied to the Moment

Mary and Julian, in different and distinct ways, hold open the moment for discernment, for judgment to be given both the space and the time to evaluate, ponder, and run through the kata, to have interior disposition meet the moment. This is what Aquinas means by *conscientia*: to apply knowledge to the moment of the encounter, to stand in

that moment with agency, with accountability, after having discerned what to do and when to do it, and why: for the common good guided by UDG and CST.

The Silicon Valley Inversion

The dominant culture of technological development has made a virtue and an economy out of the systematic elimination of the threshold between discernment and action. *Move fast and break things. Ship before you're ready.* This is *wu wei* inverted. The timing belt has not merely been neglected; it has been removed and celebrated in its removal. The *Grammar of Agency* names this clearly: the elimination of the timing belt is a moral failure. The recovery of *wu wei* is the only path back to agency, autonomy, and authentic human moral action.

The Agent-Influencer-Witness Triad

No moral moment is inhabited by one person alone. The **Agent** is the human moral actor who performs the *actus* — who carries the vertical axis and bears sole responsibility for the act. The **Influencer** is any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts, but does not act in the Agent's place. The **Witness** is the tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment and testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. When autonomy is intact and the *kata* is running cleanly, the Witness remains silent.

The Witness Moment

Everything in the *Grammar of Agency* converges on a single instant: the **Witness Moment**. This is the *actus* — the decisive, embodied action of the agent — the hinge between intention and consequence, the only moment where agency is real. An AI cannot create a Witness Moment. It can process the field. It can describe what a witness moment looks like. It cannot stand in one — because standing requires presence, and presence requires a soul.

Section IV: In Dialogue with Magnifica Humanitas

Magnifica Humanitas and the *Grammar of Agency* are written for the same moment and share the same diagnosis. This section draws the two documents into explicit conversation across their most significant points of contact.

Shared Diagnosis: The Hollow Shell

The encyclical's central anthropological warning is that AI's danger is not that machines become moral agents but that human beings, through habituated outsourcing, cease to exercise genuine moral judgment.^[11] The *Grammar* names the same dynamic as “the mechanism of displacement”: outsourcing that reshapes the agent. Both documents converge on the same conclusion: the most urgent task in an age of artificial intelligence is the formation of human agency — not information transfer, not technique acquisition, but the slow, deliberate, habituated shaping of the moral person so that when the moment arrives, the right act arises not from calculation but from character.

What AI Cannot Do: Convergent Claims

Leo XIV states that AI systems “do not possess a moral conscience, since they do not judge good and evil, grasp the ultimate meaning of situations, or bear responsibility for consequences.”^[5] The Grammar translates this into operational terms: AI lives permanently on the horizontal plane and cannot enter the Witness Moment, which requires presence, soul, and the capacity to stand before the good. An AI response is not an act. It does not stand before the good. It does not choose.

Universal Destination of Goods: The Structural Condition

This is the encyclical’s most significant doctrinal extension into the digital context. Leo XIV writes: “In a context where the wealth of nations depends increasingly on knowledge and technology, when these goods remain concentrated in the hands of a few, without adequate forms of sharing and access, a new imbalance is created that contradicts the universal destination of goods.”^[7]

The Grammar incorporates this as the initial altitude instrument not merely as a doctrinal nod but as a structural condition of justice. The encyclical goes further: “to speak of the universal destination of goods means finding ways of ensuring universal access to both technologies and the education needed to use them.”^[12] The Grammar itself — offered as “seed to be spread” in its preface — is a concrete expression of this principle: formation architecture held as common patrimony, not proprietary enclosure.

Truth as Common Good: The Torres Connection

Magnifica Humanitas’ sustained treatment of truth as a common good threatened by algorithmic disinformation finds its micro-level demonstration in the Torres case study. When the timing belt is removed and AI fluency substitutes for verification, truth collapses not through bad intent but through “authority laundering” — each actor assuming someone upstream has already checked. Justice Buchanan’s prescription is the institutional grammar of *wu wei*: a structured pause, a non-negotiable moment of discernment. The encyclical names the same requirement at the democratic level: “only the shared pursuit of the veracity of facts, perceived as a common good, can provide a solid foundation for just communication.”^[13]

Subsidiarity and the Timing Belt

Leo XIV’s application of subsidiarity to the digital age — insisting that algorithmic processes not be “imposed from above in an opaque and unilateral manner” and that communities retain the ability to “discern and oversee”^[14] — finds its interior counterpart in *wu wei*. Subsidiarity is, at the social level, the institutional equivalent of the timing belt: the insistence that decisions be made at the closest level to the persons involved, resisting the compression of discernment by speed and scale. Both documents are making the same structural argument at different altitudes.

The Civilization of Love and the Grammar’s Project

The encyclical’s culminating vision — “the civilization of love in the digital age” — names the social project toward which the Grammar’s interior formation work is ordered.

Leo XIV invokes the Nehemiah image: rebuilding through shared responsibility, “brick by brick.”^[15] The Grammar’s formation architecture is the interior brick-laying that makes that shared project possible. The encyclical concludes with Mary’s Magnificat as the song of hope. The Grammar concludes with Mary’s fiat as the perfected integration of *wu wei* and *recta ratio agibilium*. Both documents end at the same threshold: the formed human person, standing ready, in the presence of the Lord, prepared to act.

Section V: The Grammar in Action — Case Studies

Theory without demonstration is philosophy. The Grammar makes its strongest claims in concrete moments.

Case Study 1: The Taffy Toss

The Objective Narrative

A seminar room. Thirteen seats arranged around a table, six occupied. Without preamble, the presenter turns away and reaches for saltwater taffy — enough for thirteen, though only six are present. He turns back and tosses the candy across the table in a single, generous motion. The taffy scatters freely. There is more than enough. Resources are unlimited.

The presenter turns away again. This time, when he turns back, he holds a single Kind bar. He does not toss it. He walks to the table and places it — deliberately, quietly, without comment. He steps back. He says nothing. He waits.

Nobody takes the Kind bar.

The Analysis

The taffy toss is the AI operating environment made visible. Unlimited resources across an open field. Relational access, instantaneous availability, no moral weight. AI lives permanently in the toss. It cannot do what happens next.

The Kind bar placement is a different category of action entirely. The presenter has framed, received and sensed, oriented and aligned — and then held the timing belt. *Wu wei* between Orient and Act. The threshold honored. Only then the placement: deliberate, quiet, without explanation. Nobody takes the Kind bar because a human being acted deliberately, is present and waiting. The participants feel that presence before their minds can form a thought about it.

Notice also the universal destination dimension: the taffy is offered in abundance — more than enough for all thirteen, though only six are present. This is the posture of goods held as common patrimony. The Kind bar introduces scarcity and deliberate placement — the moment when the question of who receives and why becomes moral. *Magnifica Humanitas*’ initial altitude instrument is visible in the contrast: the toss enacts universal destination; the Kind bar placement asks the agent to discern it.

Case Study 2: The Buddhist March on Petersburg

The Buddhist foot-marchers come in slow and steady. Their saffron robes catch the winter sun. Padding alongside them is Ashoka, the stray mutt who adopted them somewhere around Dinwiddie and never left. Inside the old tobacco auction house, long tables are already set: cornbread, dal, collards, dumplings, sweet potato pies, and a pot of something spicy that no one can identify but everyone wants to try. The field is warm, open, unguarded.

From the far corner: “This is syncretism! Buddhism doesn’t march with Christians!” The field wobbles. What happens next is proportionate — each response the product of a formed disposition expressing itself through the timing belt:

- The Buddhist monk bows slightly: “We walk with whoever walks.”
- The Methodist pastor: “Hospitality isn’t dilution. It’s hospitality.”
- The Wiccan teen shrugs: “We’re literally just here for the dog.”
- The AME choir director laughs: “If you think this is syncretism, you’ve never been to a potluck.”

None of these responses could have been scripted or generated by AI. Each required embodied presence, read context, and moral character formed over time. Each was an *actus* in the full Thomistic sense. The long tables of food are also relevant: they enact precisely what *Magnifica Humanitas* calls the civilization of love translated into the analog — goods held in common, the feast as the social form of solidarity.

Case Study 3: In re Torres Campos

Torres demonstrates JPP’s complete systematic collapse across an entire professional chain.^[3] The field was modest on its surface: a post-dissolution dispute over visitation of a dog named Kyra. What entered the field was not malice but the comfortable assumption that someone upstream had already done the checking. Munoz found a citation in a Reddit article and believed it. Bonar received it from her client and cited it without reading it. Torres’s counsel drafted a proposed order repeating the fiction without verifying it. The commissioner signed it. The hallucination became the record.

Frame: Absent at every node

No actor achieved field awareness. None asked: what is this, exactly, and where did it come from? The Frame move is not a technical legal skill. It is a human act of situational awareness.

Receive and Sense: Suppressed by fluency

AI hallucination defeats the sensing function. The citation arrived in fluent prose with proper format, plausible party names, a realistic year and reporter, and a holding that fits the argument. The signal that should trigger verification never fires.

Orient and Align: Displaced by proximate good	Each actor oriented toward a proximate good (win the motion, draft efficiently, serve the client) without aligning with the deeper good. When confronted with evidence of the fiction, Bonar doubled down — Orient and Align inverted: oriented toward self-protection and away from truth.
Timing Belt: Never engaged	The question the timing belt holds open — <i>have I verified this?</i> — was never asked by any actor. The tea was never steeped. Justice Buchanan’s prescription is the institutional grammar of <i>wu wei</i>: a non-negotiable moment of discernment before the act proceeds.

Three Additions to the Grammar from Torres

Authority Laundering. Each actor assumed someone upstream had verified. This is a structural illusion of already-performed sensing that had, in fact, never occurred at any link. The Grammar needs this category.

The Cascade Architecture. The cascade is a systems failure that emerges from the simultaneous absence of the timing belt at every node, not a failure of any one actor’s character.

The Institutional Witness. The Court of Appeal, in a published opinion, performed the witness function for an entire professional system. Justice Buchanan’s recommendation is the institutional Witness’s act.

Section VI: Crisis Subrouting: The Irrational Agent

Non-Violent, Actively Passive Containment

The standard JPP kata presupposes shared rational ground. When these are absent, the horizontal plane ceases to function as a field for influence. The containment protocol addresses what happens when the field itself has collapsed. It functions as a **conditional subroutine overlay**, activated only when irrationality is encountered *after* the Witness Moment matrix has already authorized testimony. Irrationality is a mode switch, not a trigger: it does not initiate the moral intervention — it only alters the execution path once intervention is already required.

Foundational Axiom

Irrational actors cannot be influenced; they can only be bounded.

The Five Rules of Containment

Rule 1 Terrain Refusal	Do not attempt to win within an irrational actor's frame. Shift the frame, change the terrain. Deny the irrational frame the opportunity to become the operative environment.
Rule 2 Boundary Shifting	The central question becomes: "how do we protect people and outcomes from instability?" Boundaries do not argue, threaten, or persuade. They <i>exist</i> , are stated once, and enforced procedurally. Ease a new platform, shift to it with a perceived benefit from the other side.
Rule 3 Audience Removal	Irrational behavior feeds on reaction, moral theater, and attention loops. Reduce channels. Prefer written, minimal cadence. Silence here is noise reduction, not punishment.
Rule 4 Exit Preservation	Even when exits are not perceived, they must exist. Offramps remain visible, language remains nonhumiliating, cornering statements are avoided. Exits are kept available in case perception recovers.
Rule 5 Time Compression	Irrationality thrives in open loops. Shorten timelines, reduce variables, create decision gates. "By Friday, either X occurs, or we proceed without." This reduces panic rather than inducing it.

Prohibited Actions

The following increase escalation risk and are disallowed:

- public exposure of hypocrisy
- acceleration to “force clarity”
- moralizing or shaming language
- threats involving consequences the actor cannot evaluate
- emotional “one last try” appeals

These feel productive. They are how violence enters systems.

CST Hard Stop: Does the act promote Human Dignity? If not, stop.

Connection to Magnifica Humanitas

Magnifica Humanitas warns against the “normalization of war” and the cultural erosion of the threshold between discernment and force: “the use of force, violence and weapons reflects a relational poverty that always has disastrous consequences.”^[16] The containment doctrine is the micro-level instantiation of exactly this concern. The prohibition on moralizing, shaming, and escalation-as-clarity is the household-scale equivalent of the encyclical’s call to “disarm words” before disarming weapons.

The encyclical’s insistence on exit preservation and the hard constraint on human dignity^[17] maps directly onto Rules 4 and 5 and the CST Hard Stop. Containment is precisely the discipline of maintaining the other’s dignity as a person even when they are temporarily incapable of maintaining their own rational agency.

Redemption: Retain, Retrain, Restrain

After Containment, what? The failure of the Agent in a moral act (by misreading, failing to discern, lack of timing belt) cannot be left unsupported following perturbation in the field. The community’s response is to rebuild. The protocol is retain, retrain, and restrain.

Human dignity demands that the failed agent be retained. Where the agent is willing to acknowledge the failure (repentance) and to learn and move forward (penance), the community undertakes retraining—holding fast to its values, beginning with love. Finally, restrain: a limiting of outward projection while the agent regains stability, preventing premature action and compounding error, while interior integration takes hold.

This process not only restores balance in the agent, but, through recovery, generates insight. The recovered agent becomes a witness to failure endured and integrated, able to form others with greater clarity through the charity that arises from recovery. In this way, grace under pressure produces poise not only for the individual but also becomes a gift for the community.

Section VII: The Dominican Lineage

Contemplata Aliis Tradere

The *Grammar of Agency* emerges from within the Dominican intellectual tradition — the tradition that produced Thomas Aquinas and animated the Order of Preachers for eight centuries under the principle *contemplata aliis tradere*: share with others the fruits of contemplation.

Contemplation and action are not opposed but sequential. The formed agent first receives — in prayer, in study, in community — and then gives. Aquinas did not just study; he prayed before he wrote. St. Hyacinth of Poland: six months of formation at Santa Sabina under Dominic himself — and then twenty-five thousand miles on foot. The six months was exactly sufficient — because formation is not about the quantity of content transmitted but the quality of disposition formed. Dominic set the gyroscope spinning. It kept spinning through every field disturbance the mission encountered.

Section VIII: What the Lay Mission Institute Is For

The Lay Mission Institute exists to form lay missionary disciples — lay persons who carry the Dominican charism of truth-seeking, truth-living, and truth-sharing into the specific fields of their vocations. The *Grammar of Agency* articulates what the tradition has always known and practiced — now enriched by Taoist wisdom on timing and silence, and in dialogue with the most recent development of Catholic Social Teaching.

The capstone claim is simple. The gyroscope must be spinning before the moment arrives. The timing belt must be internalized before the field disturbance. The kata must be in the body before the Witness Moment calls it forward.

| *Only the formed human agent can place the Kind bar and wait.*

Conclusion: The Recovery of Human Agency

Magnifica Humanitas frames the choice of our era as between building the Tower of Babel — a project of pride, efficiency, and self-sufficiency that ultimately dehumanizes — and rebuilding Jerusalem, “piece by piece,” through shared responsibility, in the presence of God.^[18] The *Grammar of Agency* is the interior architecture of the Jerusalem project: not the city plan, but the formation of the builders.

The encyclical asks: does AI “make human life on earth ‘more human’ in every aspect of that life? Does it make it more worthy of man?”^[19] The Grammar answers that question from the inside: yes, if and only if the human beings who inhabit the AI age have been formed — their gyroscopes spinning, their stabilizers active, their timing belts internalized, their dispositions tuned, and their presence real.

The System	
<i>Catholic Social Teaching + Universal Destination of Goods</i>	Provides altitude — the what and why of the moral field, extended to digital goods, data, and algorithmic access.
<i>JPP</i>	Provides motion — the repeatable kata that forms disposition through praxis.
<i>Wu Wei</i>	Provides timing — the threshold between discernment and action.
<i>Tensegrity</i>	Provides stability — structural balance of tension and compression under load.
<i>Containment Protocol</i>	Provides the subroutine overlay when the field collapses — nonviolent, dignity-preserving.

Artificial intelligence will continue to shape the field. It will process, predict, and propose. But it cannot stand in the Witness Moment. It cannot bear responsibility. It cannot choose the good.

The future will belong to those who can hold the threshold open long enough for discernment to complete its work.

The person who has been formed will meet the moment.

The person who has not been formed will reach for the taffy.

The Grammar of Agency exists to assist in the formation of the person who places the Kind bar and waits.

Glossary of CST-JPP Terms

This Glossary is the Rosetta Stone for the Grammar of Agency: it defines the core terms phenomenologically, in the moment of the moral act.

Actus	The decisive, embodied action taken by the Agent. The hinge between intention and consequence. The only moment where agency is real.
Agent	The human moral actor who performs actus. Carries the vertical axis (faith, hope, love) and is solely responsible for action unless autonomy is overridden.
Authority Laundering	The structural illusion of already-performed sensing: each actor assumes someone upstream has verified, producing a cascade where no one has. Identified in Torres as distinct from Timing Drift.
Con+Facere	To make with. The moral moment is formed by the Agent, the Influencer(s), and the Witness. Formation is always communal.
CST Fourfold Test	The primary altitude instrument: Does this restore human dignity? Seed the common good? Strengthen solidarity? Uplift the little ones?
Universal Destination of Goods	The initial altitude instrument, added in dialogue with Magnifica Humanitas which extended UDG to algorithms, data, digital platforms, and formation resources. Precedes the fourfold test as a structural condition of justice.
Horizontal Plane	The stabilizing field of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, Temperance. LLM-legible but insufficient alone.

Influencer	Any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts. Does not act in the Agent's place.
JPP	Judgment-Premised Processing. The steering mechanism — a kata for navigating chaotic moments with clarity and proportion.
Tensegrity	Structural stability through dynamic balance of tension and compression. The architecture holds under load not through rigidity but through balanced forces.
Threshold	The liminal space between Orient & Align and Act & Integrate.
Timing Drift	The failure mode where action precedes discernment, often due to misreading the field rather than failure of character.
Vertical Axis	Faith, Hope, Love — the human-only virtues. Cannot be computed or automated. Orient the Agent toward meaning, purpose, and moral depth.
Witness	The tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment. Testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy.
Witness Moment	The instant of actus when the Agent penetrates the horizontal plane and the vertical axis enters the world. Where the wind hits the sail. Where action becomes testimony.
Wu Wei	From the classical Taoist tradition of ancient China: Lao Tzu, Tao Te Ching (6th c. BCE). The discipline of active restraint between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate. Where

Aquinas gives the what of right judgment, wu wei gives the when. Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

Footnotes

^[1] *Leo XIV, Magnifica Humanitas (15 May 2026). Issued on the 135th anniversary of Leo XIII's Rerum Novarum. Primary dialogue text for The Grammar.*

^[2] *Magnifica Humanitas, §99, §112. The encyclical states AI systems 'do not undergo experiences, do not possess a body, do not feel joy or pain, do not mature through relationships.'*

^[3] *In re the Domestic Partnership of Joan Pablo Torres Campos (March 5, 2026, California Court of Appeal, Fourth Appellate District, No. D085584).*

^[4] *Magnifica Humanitas, §92, citing Francis, Laudato Si' (2015), §106-109.*

^[5] *Magnifica Humanitas, §99.*

^[6] *Magnifica Humanitas, §134.*

^[7] *Magnifica Humanitas, §67.*

^[8] *John Paul II, Centesimus Annus (1991), §31, as cited in Magnifica Humanitas, §65.*

^[9] *Magnifica Humanitas, §75, citing Francis, Fratelli Tutti (2020), §116.*

^[10] *Magnifica Humanitas, §92-95, §107.*

^[11] *Magnifica Humanitas, §112: 'the pervasive technocratic paradigm...threatens to normalize an anti-human vision.'*

^[12] *Magnifica Humanitas, §109.*

^[13] *Magnifica Humanitas, §132.*

^[14] *Magnifica Humanitas, §71.*

^[15] *Magnifica Humanitas, §8, citing Neh 2-6.*

^[16] *Magnifica Humanitas, §192.*

^[17] *Magnifica Humanitas, §53, citing Dignitas Infinita (2024), §1: 'Every human person possesses an infinite dignity, inalienably grounded in his or her very being.'*

^[18] *Magnifica Humanitas, §7-9.*

^[19] *Magnifica Humanitas, §129, citing John Paul II, Redemptor Hominis (1979), §15.*

^[20] *Anna Rowlands, Towards a Politics of Communion: Catholic Social Teaching in Dark Times (London: Bloomsbury / T&T Clark, 2021).*

^[21] *Simone Weil, The Need for Roots, trans. Arthur Wills (1949); on attention, "Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies," in Waiting for God.*

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